

Life's dilemmas: Lessons from everyday conflicts

We should recognise the value of **pausing** and **reflecting**, to determine whether our reactions to **perceived** insults are genuinely justified

We face conflicts and dilemmas many times in our lives. We **resolve** a few of those, avoiding others to avoid **confrontation**.

We **went through** some **fascinating** times recently. We **cast our votes** to elect the next central government. The **excitement** of the crowd at the polling booth **was palpable** even early in the morning. There was another major event, which was at our society level. We also had elections for the governing body of our residents' welfare association.

I realised that the two elections **mirrored** each other. New **alliances** were formed, and old ones were **discarded**. **Sworn foes** smiled at each other with a **warmth** not unlike the hot Delhi summers. There were many heartbreaks too if friends **vied** for the same position. Two of the **prospective** candidates for a position went about **venting** their frustration when told by well-meaning friends about the intent of the other. I suggested a mutual **tete-a-tete**. The conflict was resolved.

I faced a dilemma as an **adolescent** half a century back. One afternoon, I had an argument with a friend, which **went a little overboard**, and I **punched** him. He was taller than me and did not take kindly to my aggression. He punched me back. It did not **erupt** into a **full-blown fist** fight only because I had already **rationalised** his punch a little before it had connected with my soft **abdomen**. After all, I had started the battle; he was **entitled** to **retaliate**.

Many of us hesitate to ask for personal favour, **apprehensive** of facing rejection. It is also a dilemma, **albeit** in our minds. I **had no say** in the **allotment** of the zonal railways after the completion of our railway probation training. I did get an opportunity to express my heart's desire, when my senior asked me if I had any preference for the place of posting. I was **diffident** and I gave a **convoluted** reply, "Anywhere, though my preference would be Mughalsarai." This was a small town in my **native** state. He took the first part of my statement **at face value**. I was posted at Sealdah, the other end, and a long way from my hometown - physically, **linguistically**, and culturally.

I understood much later in life the importance of plain speaking, however **unpalatable** it might be. It may cause initial **bitterness**, but the relationship would be stronger **eventually**. The self-realisation still did not give me the courage to **upbraid** a junior colleague for his **tardiness**. I chose to walk away from confrontation by not allocating him any responsibilities.

I **envy** those who have **mastered sugar-coating the bitter pill**. It softens the **blow**, yet hits the person equally hard. But it might even convey a wrong meaning. During a recent conversation, my wife and her friend **contemplated** conveying a rather difficult **sentiment** to another friend through a message. A small phrase was added to be **polite**. I felt that this changed the intent to something entirely different. They did not agree and chose not to send the message. Yet, the friend had not hesitated to upbraid another friend a few days earlier over a **trivial** issue. I saw conflict in the two situations, she did not.

Conflicts have been a part of our lives since ages. I would not like to be the Arjun who faced the biggest challenge of his life. I am a **mere mortal**. I have my **follies**. It is not for me to **preach** to be perfect. I would look at the words of author Jo Coudert to give me strength, "Every life is a dilemma that must be solved by the person living it."

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Dilemma** (noun) – Predicament, quandary, problem, difficulty, impasse द्विधा
2. **Pausing** (noun) – Stopping, halting, pausing briefly, delaying, breaking विराम
3. **Reflecting** (noun) – Thinking, contemplating, considering, meditating, pondering चिंतन
4. **Perceived** (adjective) – Believed, considered, viewed, regarded, seen अनुभूत
5. **Resolve** (verb) – Settle, solve, address, deal with, rectify हल करना
6. **Confrontation** (noun) – Conflict, clash, encounter, showdown, dispute आमना-सामना
7. **Go through** (phrasal verb) – Experience, undergo, endure, face, confront गुजरना
8. **Fascinating** (adjective) – Captivating, intriguing, interesting, engaging, enchanting आकर्षक
9. **Cast vote** (phrase) – Vote, participate in election, exercise the right to vote, ballot मतदान करना
10. **Palpable** (adjective) – Noticeable, tangible, evident, perceptible, apparent स्पष्ट
11. **Mirror** (verb) – Reflect, resemble, match, imitate, echo प्रतिबिंबित करना
12. **Alliance** (noun) – Coalition, partnership, association, union, collaboration गठबंधन
13. **Discard** (verb) – Abandon, throw away, dispose of, reject, get rid of त्यागना
14. **Sworn foes** (noun) – Archenemies, adversaries, rivals, opponents, antagonists शत्रु
15. **Warmth** (noun) – Friendliness, affection, kindness, cordiality, heat गर्मजोशी
16. **Vie** (verb) – Compete, contest, battle, strive, contend प्रतिस्पर्धा करना
17. **Prospective** (adjective) – Potential, possible, likely, future, expected संभावित
18. **Vent** (verb) – Express, release, let out, air, unload व्यक्त करना
19. **Tete-a-tete** (noun) – Private conversation, one-on-one, dialogue, discussion, chat एकांत वार्तालाप
20. **Adolescent** (adjective) – Teenage, youthful, immature, juvenile, in youth किशोर
21. **Go overboard** (phrase) – Exaggerate, go too far, overreact, exceed limits, be excessive अति करना
22. **Punch** (verb) – Hit, strike, blow, thump, jab मुक्का मारना

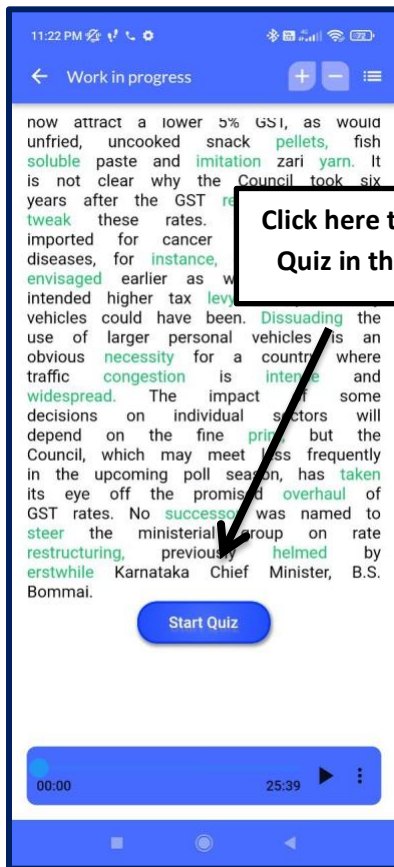
23. **Erupt** (verb) – Explode, burst, break out, flare up, blow up फटना
24. **Full-blown** (adjective) – Complete, fully developed, extensive, mature, comprehensive पूर्ण विकसित
25. **Fist** (noun) – Clenched hand, closed hand, hand, punch, knuckle मुक्का, घुंसा
26. **Rationalise** (verb) – Justify, explain, reason, defend, make excuses तर्कसंगत बनाना
27. **Abdomen** (noun) – Stomach, belly, midsection, torso, gut पेट
28. **Entitle** (to) (verb) – Authorize, allow, qualify, empower, give rights हक देना
29. **Retaliate** (verb) – Take revenge, respond, react, strike back, reciprocate प्रतिशोध लेना
30. **Apprehensive** (of) (adjective) – Worried, anxious, concerned, fearful, uneasy आशंकित/ सशंक
31. **Albeit** (Conjunction) – Although, even though, despite, notwithstanding, though यद्यपि
32. **Have no say** (phrase) – No control, no influence, no decision-making power, no input, powerless कोई अधिकार न होना
33. **Allotment** (noun) – Allocation, assignment, distribution, portion, share आवंटन
34. **Diffident** (adjective) – Shy, hesitant, insecure, unconfident, timid संकोची
35. **Convolutd** (adjective) – Complicated, complex, intricate, tangled, involved जटिल
36. **At face value** (noun) – At first glance, as it appears, superficially, without questioning, straightforwardly बिना गहराई में जाए
37. **Linguistically** (adverb) – Related to language, in terms of language, language-wise भाषायी दृष्टि से
38. **Unpalatable** (adjective) – Unpleasant, distasteful, disagreeable, unacceptable, unappealing अप्रिय
39. **Bitterness** (noun) – Resentment, animosity, acrimony, harshness, sourness कड़वाहट
40. **Eventually** (adverb) – Finally, ultimately, in the end, at last, after some time अंततः
41. **Upbraid** (verb) – Scold, reprimand, rebuke, criticize, admonish फटकारना
42. **Tardiness** (noun) – Lateness, delay, slowness, unpunctuality, procrastination विलंब
43. **Envy** (verb) – Covet, desire, resent, begrudge, be jealous of ईर्ष्या करना
44. **Master** (verb) – Control, dominate, learn, perfect, become proficient in महारत हासिल करना

45. **Sugar-coating the bitter pill** (phrase) – making unpleasant things more acceptable
46. **Blow** (noun) – Shock, setback, hit, impact, trauma आघात
47. **Contemplate** (verb) – Consider, think about, ponder, reflect on, deliberate विचार करना
48. **Sentiment** (noun) – Feeling, emotion, attitude, opinion, belief भावना
49. **Polite** (adjective) – Courteous, respectful, well-mannered, civil, tactful विनम्र
50. **Trivial** (adjective) – Unimportant, insignificant, minor, petty, negligible तुच्छ
51. **Mere** (adjective) – Simple, only, nothing more than, just, pure मात्र
52. **Mortal** (noun) – Human, being, person, creature, individual नश्वर प्राणी
53. **Folly** (noun) – Foolishness, stupidity, recklessness, imprudence, error मूर्खता
54. **Preach** (verb) – Advocate, promote, sermonize, teach, spread उपदेश देना

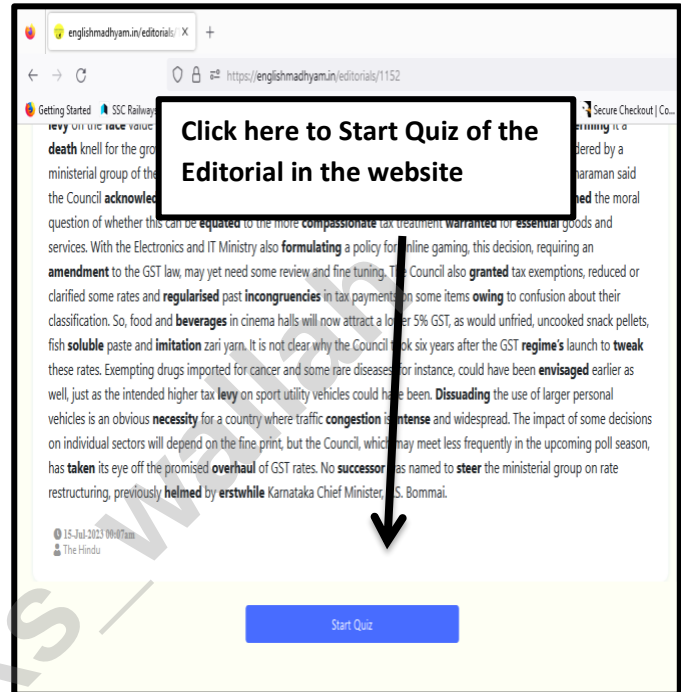
Summary of the Editorial

1. The editorial emphasizes the importance of pausing and reflecting before reacting to perceived insults, ensuring that responses are genuinely justified.
2. Conflicts and dilemmas are common in life, and while some are resolved, others are avoided to prevent confrontation.
3. The author shares personal experiences of recent elections, both at the national level and within a residential society, highlighting the parallels between the two.
4. Elections often bring new alliances and break old ones, with former foes appearing friendly due to the circumstances.
5. Personal conflicts can be intense but also resolvable through dialogue, as seen in the author's experience with two candidates vying for the same position.
6. Reflecting on an adolescent argument that escalated into a physical altercation, the author highlights the importance of rationalizing conflicts and accepting responsibility for one's actions.
7. The editorial discusses the dilemma of asking for personal favors and the fear of rejection, emphasizing that hesitation can lead to missed opportunities.
8. An example of diffidence during the author's railway posting shows the impact of not speaking plainly and how it resulted in an undesired outcome.
9. Plain speaking, though it may cause initial bitterness, ultimately strengthens relationships, a lesson the author learned later in life.
10. The author reflects on avoiding confrontation by not assigning responsibilities to a tardy colleague, choosing to walk away from potential conflict.
11. The skill of sugar-coating harsh truths is envied by the author, but he acknowledges that it can sometimes convey unintended meanings.
12. A recent conversation about conveying a difficult sentiment through a polite message illustrates the challenge of balancing honesty with diplomacy.
13. The author contrasts their own approach to conflict with that of others who may be more direct in addressing issues, even trivial ones.
14. Conflict is presented as an inevitable part of life, with the author acknowledging personal imperfections and the challenges of navigating dilemmas.
15. The editorial concludes with a quote from author Jo Coudert, reminding readers that every life is a dilemma that must be solved by the individual living it.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



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